accept the Congress as the pivot of the Opposition unity. In fact, most of the INDIA alliance partners often complained of the inaccessibility of the office of the Congress president, swinging between Sonia Gandhi and Rahul Gandhi, before Kharge entered the scene. Kharge has been accessible and responsive. And despite being the first non-Gandhi Congress president in nearly 25 years, he has been able to walk the tightrope with a fine balance. For all crucial decisions such as alliance-building and chief ministerial selection, the Gandhi family's approval is a must and dutifully sought. But for the day-to-day running of the party, Kharge is his own man.

The people are gradually recognising the return of some order in how the Congress party is being run. In the August edition of the India Today Mood of the Nation (MOTN) poll, 43 per cent of the respondents rate the performance of the Congress as an Opposition party as outstanding or good—against 41 per cent in January 2021. Kharge's efforts have got a thumbs-up with 47 per cent of the respondents saying that his performance as Congress president has been either outstanding or good.

But the larger share of credit for the party's improved public perception goes to former Congress president Rahul Gandhi. In the past one year, the Gandhi scion has been uncharacteristically consistent in his political discourse and public visibility. On multiple occasions, he led the party's attack on PM Modi in Parliament. Between September 2022 and January 2023, he completed the 4,000-km-long Bharat Jodo Yatra (BJY)—a walkathon from Kanyakumari to Kashmir. The yatra not only instilled a sense of rejuvenation within the party organisation but also massively enhanced Rahul's image among voters. In the MOTN poll, 44 per cent of the respondents say their impression of the Congress leader after the BJY has changed for the better.

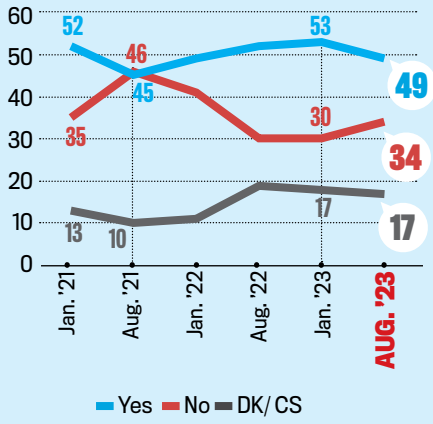
In fact, he has been paying extra attention to recast himself as a caring, sensitive and accessible mass leader, unlike the "Pappu" caricature—a privileged, clueless person—popularised by the right-wing social media army. He has now found a new way to reach out to a larger mass by releasing on social media his video-recorded interactions with the marginal classes of society such as farmers, daily-wagers and truckers. At other times, he is giving interviews to social media influencers who ask him about his education, food choices and other finer details of his personality.

The attention to the public image was evident when he refused to apologise after a Gujarat court convicted and punished him with a two-year jail term in a defamation case, earning him a disqualification from Parliament. Rahul, instead, took the fight to the Supreme Court, which gave him a reprieve five months later. His aides say the decision not to apologise and seek an escape route was a carefully thought-out one.

The idea was to showcase Rahul as an upright politician who was ready to stand by his words and beliefs. He could not be intimidated with harsh legal action or political counterstrike. "He proved that he has it in him to take on the might of the Modi government and remain unshaken by their dirty political tactics," says one of his close confidants. In the MOTN poll, 31 per cent of the respondents feel that the decision to disqualify Rahul from Parliament was totally unlawful and politically motivated while another 21 per cent think it was a harsh decision even though it was lawful.

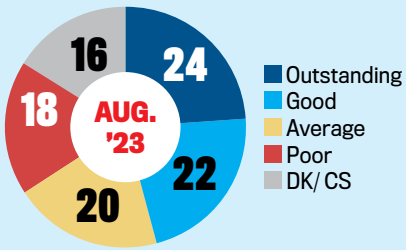
Though he did not campaign in Himachal Pradesh and his participation in Karnataka was minimal, the electoral victories in these two states have strengthened his position within the party and also among potential allies. In the MOTN poll, 32 per cent of the respondents say he is the best-suited

Q. Will the Congress be better-off without the Gandhi family?



Almost half say the Congress will do better without the Gandhi family, almost 3 percentage points less than in January 2023

Q. How would you rate Mallikarjun Kharge's performance as Congress president?



Kharge's efforts as Congress party president have been recognised by nearly half

47%

OF RESPONDENTS THINK KHARGE'S PERFORMANCE AS CONGRESS CHIEF HAS BEEN OUTSTANDING OR GOOD